CHAPTER 15

RENEWAL

Birthdays can bring everything into focus. I turned 31 during the 2015 Cricket World Cup, and celebrated the occasion in Melbourne.

I was another year older, another year wiser … and another year more sore first thing in the morning. At stages, it might be an ache deep within my right shoulder that becomes more acute when I throw the ball, or it could be the pain shooting through my left knee when I set off for a quick single, or it is the general discomfort in my ankle when I need to change direction, either while fielding or batting.

Such niggles and aches are an unavoidable part of every professional sporting life. Very few players ever run onto the field feeling completely fit and pain-free, and 'pain-free' is not a phrase that often applies to international cricketers, like me, who have played all three formats of the game for 12 consecutive seasons.

I didn't say anything to anyone beyond my inner circle of family and friends, didn't want to appear either weak or half-hearted but, moving into 2015, I was feeling the physical strain.

Maybe I haven't managed my body well through all these years. Maybe I should have withdrawn from the team whenever I wasn't feeling even 90% fit, and given various ailments time to heal. Maybe I should have developed the 'professional' knack of putting my own welfare first, pulling back, shifting down a gear or two and easing the strain without ever